

Southwest monsoon ends with 12% deficit, October rain also likely below normal: IMD

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NEW DELHI

India's 2026 southwest monsoon ended with 759.4 mm of rain, 12.6% below the 868.6-mm normal, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Wednesday. At 87% of the Long Period Average (LPA), this is the lowest rainfall recorded during the monsoon since 2015, which was a tad drier at 758.2 mm.

The east and northeast region, which recorded 1,017.1 mm of rainfall, had its driest monsoon since 1901, or since the IMD started to keep systematic records.

The subdued rainfall was in line with forecasts by global weather agen-

Driest in a decade

With 759.4 mm of rain, 2026 recorded the lowest monsoon rainfall since 2015, which was a tad drier at 758.2mm

2026	Long Period Average (LPA) (mm)	2026 rainfall (mm)
June	165.3	106.8 (65% of LPA)
July	280.5	283.3 (101% of LPA)
August	254.9	213.3 (84% of LPA)
Sept.	167.9	155.1 (92% of LPA)

cies, including the IMD, which anticipated one of the strongest El Ninos in recent history. The IMD had, since April, predicted a subdued monsoon rainfall and overall, reality corresponded to what was fore-

cast. On April 13, for instance, it anticipated the June-September rain to be at 92% of LPA, with an error window of 5%. The May 29 update lowered that to 90% with a 4% error window. The IMD's final esti-

mate sits within this range.

The southwest monsoon this year is in the process of withdrawal and is likely to completely exit within the first weeks of October, IMD Director-General M. Mohapatra said. The country will then see the advent of the northeast monsoon. With the El Nino still gaining strength, rainfall for the country in October is likely to be below 85% of the LPA of about 75.4 mm. Most regions are expected to get below-normal rain, except parts of northwest India, southern peninsular India, and isolated pockets of the east.

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Good foundation

The festive season looks set to build on months of strong industrial growth

India’s industrial growth performance in August continued its strong streak since the beginning of the financial year, and sets the economy up well for the upcoming festive season. Growth in the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) quickened to 8% in August 2026, the second fastest that it has been since at least April 2024, which is the earliest month for which the new series of the IIP has growth data. The fastest growth in this period, of 8.8%, came as recently as June 2026. In fact, IIP growth in the April-August period of this financial year stood at a robust 6.8%, faster than that seen during the corresponding periods of the previous two years. The new series has an updated base year, more data sources, and improved methodology, so this growth performance is as accurate an indication of industrial growth as government data can provide. Moreover, apart from a few divergences, IIP data largely match the trends evident in the Index of Core Industries (ICI), the other government index that measures industrial performance. For example, the IIP shows that the electricity sector’s growth quickened to 12.3% in August 2026, while the ICI pegs it at 11.6%. Similarly, the construction goods sector saw growth come in at a relatively strong 6.4%, albeit slower than July’s 8%. In keeping with that, the ICI shows that the cement sector grew by a robust 12.5% in August, though this was slightly slower than the 12.7% in July. The older series of both indices often provided contrary indications, so this alignment is welcome.

The IIP for August also lays out some core strengths that seem to be developing in the economy. The manufacturing sector grew by nearly 9% in August, and averaged 7.6% in the April-August 2026 period. Given that it had grown by about 4.2% in the first five months of the previous financial year, this acceleration is good to see, especially since it comes at a time when producers are facing several input-related pressures. At the start of this calendar year, manufacturing growth seemed to have been driven by a growth in exports. The August data show that this is now being supplemented by a recovery in domestic consumption. The growth in consumer durables stood at 11.1% in August. The consumer non-durables sector returned to growth, of a little more than 2%, after having contracted in July. The effect of the Goods and Services Tax rate cuts in September 2025 should have petered out by now, so this boost in durables production likely means that producers are expecting a strong festive season ahead. The third quarter of the financial year will therefore be crucial for the economy, but the groundwork seems to be in place for a relatively good one.

Bitter pills

The Supreme Court did well to intervene in drug pricing by retailers

The Supreme Court has upbraided disparities between the price to retailer (PTR) and the maximum retail price (MPR) of certain drugs, including those used to treat cancers, in some instances up to 1,000%. These drugs are not available over-the-counter, so hospitals often control which brand a patient uses. As a result, pharmaceutical companies compete for the hospitals’ business, not patients’. To incentivise a hospital to stock specific drugs, they deliberately specify inflated MRPs while offering the hospital low PTRs, and the hospital can pocket the difference. The practice does not technically amount to a kickback but is one economically, as manufacturers effectively promise hospitals an embedded financial reward to pick specific products, and leave patients to potentially pay more than the medicines’ supply price because hospitals have an incentive to sell brands with the largest margins. When private hospitals also force patients to purchase drugs from on-premise pharmacies – as Competition Commission investigations have established – patients are unable to shop around, undermining normal price competition. So, more affordable equivalent drugs are disadvantaged because of their lower revenue generation potential for hospitals. Patients, meanwhile, face severe financial strain – a concern also flagged by drug regulators in Karnataka and Maharashtra – and could, among those with cancers and chronic conditions, reduce adherence to longer treatment regimens.

The practice arises from a gap in the 2013 Drug (Prices Control) Order, which caps the final maximum price of scheduled drugs, but not the markup on hospitals’ transactions. Say the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) calculates the market-derived average price of such a drug to be ₹100, making the ceiling ₹116. If a hospital negotiates a PTR of ₹50 from the manufacturer, it can still sell the drug (or bill the government if a drug is state-financed) at ₹116, without breaching the ceiling, and enjoy the difference of ₹66. In a proof-of-concept exercise in 2019, the NPPA capped the trade margins of 42 non-schedule anti-cancer drugs at 30%. The Department of Pharmaceuticals subsequently said prices of 526 brands dropped by up to 91%, suggesting that the MRPs of several cancer drugs included compressible margins. Second, while the Court’s suggestion to have a fixed percentage markup across all drugs is appealing, it should accompany a regressive margin that applies a smaller percentage as drug prices increase, to neutralise sellers’ incentive to favour more expensive products. Overall, however, the Court is right to highlight this insidious problem, especially after refusing to intervene in *Siddharth Dalmia* (2025), and while the Union and States have failed to counterbalance the absence of natural market mechanisms to rationalise drug prices.

On October 1, 2025, the Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) between India and the four European Free Trade Association (EFTA) states – Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland – entered into force. One year on, the more useful question is not how many tariff lines have fallen, but what kind of partnership the agreement is making possible.

The tariff figures are substantial. EFTA states have offered concessions on 92.2% of their tariff lines, covering 99.6% of the value of India’s exports to them. India, in turn, is granting concessions on 82.7% of its tariff lines, covering 95.3% of the value of EFTA’s exports. Few market-opening exercises between India and a group of developed economies have been this ambitious.

Lasting partnerships, an India focus

Yet, the defining feature of TEPA lies elsewhere. It was the first trade agreement that India signed with a dedicated chapter on investment and job creation. Under it, the EFTA states aim to raise investment in India by \$100 billion over 15 years and to facilitate one million direct jobs. An agreement based on that is designed to build lasting industrial and technological partnerships.

For a country of just under 4,00,000 people, Iceland’s contribution to that partnership was never going to be about scale. It is about experience, particularly in three areas where that experience speaks directly to India’s priorities.

The first is geothermal energy, specifically a part of it that receives far less attention than power generation: the direct use of low- to medium-temperature heat. In Iceland, geothermal energy heats nearly every home, dries fish, warms greenhouses and keeps entire communities running through Arctic winters without burning fossil fuels. That century of experience in direct use is what the Himalayan geothermal belt of northern India can draw on.

Consider the apple growers of Himachal Pradesh. Many have long been forced to sell their harvest immediately, at the lowest prices of the season, because they lacked the means to store their crops.

That is now changing. At Tapri, in Kinnaur district, a geothermal facility operated by Geotropy, an Indian-Icelandic venture, uses heat drawn from the ground to dry fruit, and this harvest season, it is running round the clock as growers line up to use it.

A geothermal cooling facility at the same site is due to be completed by the end of the year. Farmers there can now process their produce



Benedikt Höskuldsson

The Ambassador of Iceland to India

An ambitious India-Europe partnership can deliver across trade, technology, energy and Arctic stewardship

and time their sales rather than remain price-takers at harvest, drawing on the same direct-use techniques that Iceland has refined over generations. Or consider the high-altitude communities and installations along India’s northern frontier, which depend on fuel hauled along supply lines that can close for months. Heat drawn directly from the ground beneath them offers something no convoy can: energy security that does not depend on the road remaining open.

The second area is carbon capture, utilisation and storage. A NITI Aayog study in 2022 estimated that India could capture some 750 million tonnes of carbon dioxide a year by 2050. The scientific foundations are being laid by the Department of Science and Technology, which has steered India’s carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS) research for years and, in December 2025, published the country’s first dedicated research and development road map for CCUS in support of the 2070 net-zero goal.

The Union Budget followed in February with an outlay of ₹20,000 crore over five years to take these technologies towards scale in power, steel, cement, refining and chemicals, while public sector companies such as the Oil and Natural Gas Corporation, NTPC Limited (formerly National Thermal Power Corporation) and Indian Oil Corporation Limited are taking the work into the field through feasibility studies, pilot projects and subsurface assessments.

This pre-commercial stage is exactly where Iceland’s experience is most valuable, on both sides of the equation. On storage, CarbFix has shown that when carbon dioxide is dissolved in water and injected into basalt, more than 95% of it turns to stone within two years; India’s Deccan Trap basalts share striking geological similarities with Iceland’s volcanic rock.

New frontiers

On utilisation, Iceland was home to the world’s first industrial-scale plant to turn captured carbon dioxide into fuel: Carbon Recycling International’s George Olah plant at Svartsengi, which began producing methanol in 2011-12. Its technology now operates on a far larger scale abroad, including in projects involving steel-sector emissions. In May, Carbon Iceland signed a memorandum of understanding with JSW Steel and Bharatya to explore a 3,00,000-tonne-a-year e-methanol project in Raigad, Maharashtra, converting steel-plant emissions into fuel using green hydrogen. The opportunity, therefore, lies less in exporting equipment than in sharing knowledge and

Household debt, financing today against tomorrow



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informal-sector employee or casual worker faces a very different risk profile. The RBI has noted that consumption-oriented borrowing remains significant, although its growth has moderated, while borrowing for productive purposes has been increasing. This should be welcomed, but should not obscure the distributional dimension of household indebtedness.

The fundamental question is why households are borrowing. If borrowing increases because incomes are rising and households are investing in houses, education or productive assets, higher indebtedness need not necessarily be a source of concern. But if borrowing is required to finance food, health care, education, housing rents, durable goods or other routine expenditures because current incomes are inadequate, debt becomes a mechanism for postponing rather than resolving the income constraint.

Digital lending platforms, instant personal loans, app-based credit and online consumer finance have substantially reduced the transaction costs associated with borrowing. The boundary between what a household can afford and what it can borrow becomes blurred. At the macroeconomic level, consumption financed through credit can support aggregate demand. At the household level, however, the same process creates future repayment obligations. When households borrow to finance health care, education, housing or old-age needs, debt is effectively substituting for inadequate social protection. In this sense, household debt is not merely an outcome of individual financial choices. It is shaped by the institutional structure of the economy.

The macroeconomic implications

Household debt has implications beyond individual borrowers. In the short run, credit expansion can stimulate consumption and support economic growth. But excessive household leverage can eventually have the opposite effect. As debt-servicing obligations rise, households reduce discretionary expenditure. Consumption becomes increasingly sensitive to

building partnerships through technology licensing, storage assessment, monitoring and verification, and the co-development of projects as India’s pilots scale up.

The third area is the ocean. Iceland’s economy was built on the sustainable management of North Atlantic fisheries, and with it came deep expertise in seafood quality, cold-chain logistics and value-added processing. Icelandic companies are already exploring how to bring further processing of North Atlantic catch to Indian shores, creating local jobs and transferring technology under the TEPA concessions.

Iceland has also shown that the greatest gains may lie in what is usually thrown away. Where most fishing nations use only 40% to 60% of each fish, Iceland now uses around 90% of every cod landed, turning skin, liver and bones into medical products, oils and feed. India does not need to catch a single additional fish to create new value, jobs and exports. It needs only to look differently at what its fleets already bring ashore.

All of this sits within a wider frame. Nearly six years of working on energy access at the United Nations, along with a seat at the table during the Paris Agreement negotiations, taught this writer that climate and energy policy are, at their core, exercises in patient and practical partnership between nations. That same spirit defines Iceland’s and India’s engagement in the Arctic. Iceland is a founding member of the Arctic Council; India has been an Observer since 2013 and has taken that role seriously, publishing its Arctic Policy in 2022 and operating the Himadri research station in Svalbard. As one of the eight Arctic States, Iceland offers India a direct and trusted bilateral channel into Arctic governance and research, complementing its multilateral engagement. For Iceland and India, energy, trade and Arctic stewardship are part of the same conversation.

Some Icelandic arithmetic

TEPA is young, but it is already showing what an ambitious, rules-based partnership between Europe and India can deliver in investment, technology and jobs, as well as in energy, fisheries and shared stewardship of a changing Arctic. It is not a rival to the European Union (EU)-India Free Trade Agreement (FTA) but a complement to it: a working model, already in force, of what the next chapter of Europe-India trade can look like. If readers will permit a small piece of Icelandic arithmetic, TEPA and the EU-India FTA are a case of one plus one equalling three. That is not competition but addition – and a rather good addition at that.

interest rates and employment conditions. The macroeconomic transmission mechanism is straightforward: Income stagnation, borrowing to sustain consumption, rising debt service, declining disposable income, weaker consumption, greater dependence on credit.

If this cycle becomes entrenched, credit ceases to be an instrument for productive investment and becomes a mechanism for sustaining consumption in the face of inadequate income growth. There is therefore a potential contradiction between credit-led consumption growth and income-led demand expansion.

The first can generate a temporary acceleration of demand. The second provides a more sustainable foundation. The policy response to rising household debt should not be simply to restrict lending. Credit is an essential component of economic development, and access to formal credit can substantially improve household welfare. The challenge is to distinguish productive credit from distress credit and asset-building borrowing from consumption smoothing under income pressure.

What the central issue is

India’s household debt story is therefore more complicated than the headline number suggests. The government has emphasised that India’s household leverage remains below that of many emerging-market peers and that household net financial savings have improved. But the central issue is not simply how much households owe. It is why they owe it, to whom they owe it, at what cost, and against what income.

The danger lies in confusing access to credit with improvement in economic welfare. The more unequal and uncertain incomes become, the greater the temptation to finance living standards through borrowing. The question before policymakers is therefore not merely how to regulate household debt, but how to build an economy in which households can live on their incomes rather than against their future incomes.

The views expressed are personal

How to finance rural prosperity

India's agricultural transformation is one of the greatest achievements of independent India. Over the past six decades, the nation has emerged as one of the world's largest producers of cereals, milk, fruits, vegetables and fisheries products. This progress was driven by visionary public policy, scientific innovation, irrigation, institutional credit and the enterprise of millions of Indian farmers.

While India's first agricultural transformation delivered food security, the next must deliver rural prosperity by enabling rural India to capture a larger share of the value created after harvest. Every agricultural commodity passes through a value chain from production to aggregation, storage, logistics, processing, branding and markets. It is along this chain that enterprises emerge, employment expands and prosperity grows. Financing this change requires moving past production credit towards financing the entire agricultural value chain.

Dairy, poultry and fisheries operate through continuous procurement and marketing cycles, generating predictable cash flows, lower inventory risks and regular working-capital turnover. However, seasonal commodities operate under a very different financial reality. Processors need to procure most of their annual raw material requirement within a short harvest window and finance inventory for the remainder of the year. A company investing ₹500 crore in a modern processing facility may require ₹700-₹800 crore simply to procure, store and carry seasonal inventory.



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Without appropriately structured working capital, even efficient enterprises struggle to remain commercially viable. While the sugar sector is also seasonal, its growth demonstrates how inventory finance and warehouse-backed lending can overcome seasonal constraints. The difference in sector growth lies not in production potential but in the way the chain is financed.

Need for new mechanisms
For more than five decades, successive reforms including bank nationalisation, rural banks, cooperative institutions and the Kisan credit card expanded production credit. India has successfully built robust institutions for financing agricultural production when national food security was the priority. It must now build robust mechanisms for financing every commercially viable activity that creates value between the farm and the final consumer.

Encouragingly, elements of such a financing ecosystem are already emerging. Banks have introduced products such as warehouse receipt financing, receivables financing, and financing for food processing and agricultural infrastructure, while agri-focused non-banking financial companies have pioneered innovative value-chain models. However, these remain isolated initiatives rather than components of a comprehensive agricultural value chain financing architecture.

The opportunity is substantial. Based on the difference between the GVA (Gross Value Added) of agriculture and allied sectors (₹48.8 lakh crore) and the institutional credit flow (₹20

lakh crore) during 2023-24, indicative estimates suggest that the financing opportunity across India's agricultural value chains could exceed ₹14 lakh crore.

While only about 10-12% of agricultural produce is processed in India, the corresponding level is estimated at around 35-45% across East, South and Southeast Asia and often exceeds 60% in many developed economies. In these economies, agricultural transformation is supported by financing systems aligned with commodity-specific value chains rather than production alone.

A comprehensive agricultural value chain financing framework should provide a diverse portfolio of financial instruments, including product finance, receivables finance, warehouse receipt finance, risk mitigation solutions and credit enhancement mechanisms. These instruments can finance the flow of goods, services and capital across the value chain, with financing decisions increasingly based on commodity-specific value chains and cash-flow analysis rather than conventional collateral alone. This will enable capital to reach farmers, input suppliers, aggregators, warehouse operators, processors, logistics providers, exporters and retailers, thereby unlocking private investment, creating rural jobs, improving farmer incomes, and accelerating rural industrialisation.

Building a solid agricultural value chain finance architecture can become one of the most consequential reforms for achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

While India's first agricultural transformation delivered food security, the next must deliver rural prosperity by enabling rural India to capture a larger share of the value created after harvest

Rise in EV adoption stresses need for ramping up charging infra

Three-wheeler EVs accounted for the States of Assam, Bihar, West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh showing higher figures in EV adoption

DATA POINT

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Pon Vasanth B.A.

India is slowly but steadily transitioning towards Electric Vehicles (EVs), with cars under the “alternative fuels” category overtaking petrol cars for the first time in August 2026, as per the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations’ (FADA).

Though the alternative fuels category included fuel types such as CNG/LPG, the overall growth in the sale of EVs was significant, as reported by *The Hindu*.

However, State-wise data shows that this growth is not uniform with notable variations even among comparable States. **Table 1** shows the share of EVs and hybrid EVs in the total registrations of all types of vehicles since 2022-23. Only the States and Union Territories (UTs) that registered at least 10,000 EVs (including hybrids) are shown in the table. As the data shows, the first five months of 2026-27 have already seen a significant increase with 12.7% (16.5 lakh) of the roughly 1.29 crore vehicles registered in India being EVs or hybrids.

While Kerala, Delhi, and Karnataka were already showing notable increases in the previous years as well, data shows that the near doubling of the share in Telangana was mainly driven by the three-wheeler segment. Three-wheeler EVs also accounted for Assam, Bihar, West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh showing higher figures. The share of EVs and hybrids in new registrations in 2026-27 will drop to well below 5% if three-wheelers are excluded, analysis showed. Tripura and Assam will drop to the lowest of 2.2% and 2.6% if three-wheelers are excluded.

The disparity between the States and UTs in EV adoption is also visible in terms of availability of EV charging infrastructure and the power consumption from EV charging stations.

Chart 1 shows the power consumption from public charging stations, excluding the heavy-duty ones predominantly used by government-operated e-buses, based on the Central Electricity Authority’s report for the financial year 2025-26. Among the 15 States/UTs with highest power consumption shown in the chart, Maharashtra outperformed other States in both the availability of number of charging locations and their usage measured by the power consumed.

While Delhi showed high usage despite relatively fewer number of charging stations, Karnataka was at the other end with highest number of charging locations but relatively lesser usage. All the other States shown in the chart lagged behind by a wide margin when compared with Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka and Maharashtra.

The map shows whether the charging infrastructure available in public places has grown in proportion to the number of EVs registered across India. It measures how many newly registered EVs share charging infrastructure in a public place. For instance, there is one charging location available for every 997 registered EVs in Assam. Karnataka, on the other hand, has a public charging facility for every 144 EVs registered between 2021-22 and 2026-27 (till August) – indicating the need for the charging infrastructure to grow in places that are adopting quickly to EVs.

Although the map does not show the concentration of the charging facilities within each State, analysis showed they are heavily concentrated in and around major urban centres. For instance, Karnataka has public charging facilities in around 6,000 locations, of which about two-thirds are located in and around Bengaluru.

Uneven growth

The data for the analysis were sourced from Vahan portal, Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) and the Central Electricity Authority (CEA). Data on charging stations sourced from BEE is as of late 2025. Sachin Swaraj is interning with The Hindu’s Data team

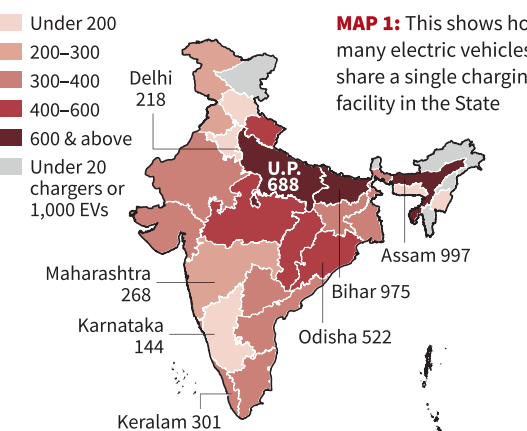
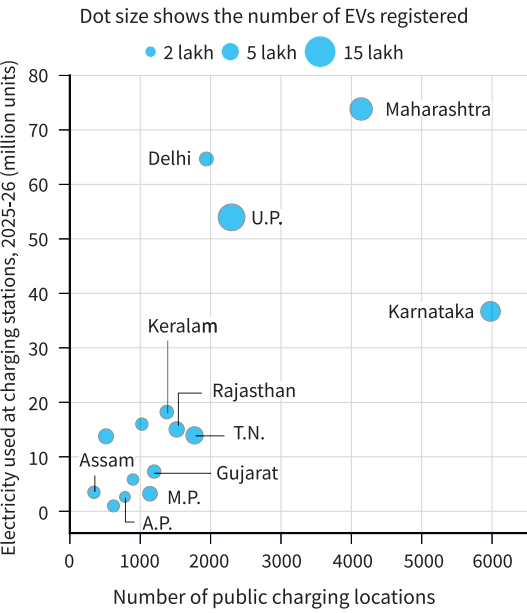


TABLE 1: This shows the share of electric vehicles (EVs) and hybrid EVs in the total number of vehicles registered. Only those States and UTs that registered at least 10,000 EVs and hybrid EVs in 2025-26 are shown

State	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25	2025-26	2026-27*
Uttar Pradesh	6.9	9.5	10.9	10.6	12.6
Maharashtra	7.7	9.5	9.6	9.2	13.1
Karnataka	8.6	11.1	11.1	12.7	16.5
Tamil Nadu	5.3	6.7	8.5	9.7	12.9
Madhya Pradesh	3.9	5.8	7.2	9.5	12.6
Keralam	8.7	13.7	14.1	15.5	18.0
West Bengal	2.2	3.4	5.2	10.6	11.6
Bihar	5.8	7.7	8.7	8.6	11.2
Rajasthan	7.4	7.1	7.4	7.6	11.8
Delhi	13.5	15.3	14.7	15.2	17.0
Gujarat	6.1	5.8	4.8	4.9	7.3
Odisha	6.1	7.8	9.3	10.9	18.7
Assam	9.0	10.9	12.4	17.0	20.7
Telangana	4.2	6.3	7.2	8.4	15.1
Andhra Pradesh	4.9	5.1	7.2	7.9	12.4
Punjab	4.6	7.0	8.5	7.7	10.2
Chhattisgarh	6.7	8.5	8.3	8.5	12.7
Haryana	5.8	6.4	6.7	5.7	6.2
Jharkhand	4.3	5.1	5.7	6.4	8.5
Uttarakhand	8.4	8.3	8.8	8.8	11.8
Jammu & Kashmir	4.9	8.5	9.7	8.3	10.3
Goa	12.1	17.0	16.1	14.7	20.1
Tripura	8.8	12.7	16.3	18.4	20.0
All India	6.4	8.1	8.8	9.5	12.7

Share (%) of EV + hybrid in all new vehicle registrations. Lightest shade is <5. Other bands are 5-8%, 8-11%, 11-14%, >14%

CHART 1: This shows the power consumed from public charging stations, when compared with the number of locations in which such infrastructure is available





Satisfaction with police remains low among cybercrime victims

Krishangi Sinha

In response, governments have expanded cyber helplines, launched the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, and established specialised cyber police stations across States. Yet, despite these institutional efforts, the Status of Policing in India Report 2026 finds that nearly two in three cybercrime victims (63%) remain dissatisfied with how the police handle their complaints, with one in five reporting being very dissatisfied. The findings suggest that while access to reporting mechanisms has improved considerably, improvements in accessibility have not been matched by victims' experience of justice, making the gap between complaint registration and effective police action the weakest link in India's cyber policing system (Table 1).

The satisfaction index combines victims' experiences across four stages: the cyber helpline, online portal, complaint registration and police investigation.

Victims report the highest satisfaction at the first point of contact, with half of helpline users expressing satisfaction (“very and somewhat satisfied”). However, confidence steadily erodes as complaints move through the system, dropping to 47% for the online portal, 46% during complaint registration, and just 43% for police investigations. The

findings suggest that the greatest challenge lies not in reporting cybercrime, but in seeing complaints through to a satisfactory resolution (Table 2).

Victims lose confidence

But the experience is not uniform. Women appear to have significantly poorer experiences than men (Table 3). While levels of moderate dissatisfaction are identical for both genders (42%), the gap widens in the most severe category. More than one in four women (26%) say they are very dissatisfied, compared to less than one in five men (18%).

For many victims, the challenge of reporting cybercrime is not only procedural but also time-consuming. 34 per cent of those who visited a police station to complain to the police waited two to three hours, while another 14% spent more than four hours before receiving assistance. Only 29% were attended to within an hour (Table 4). The findings suggest that lengthy waiting times continue to shape citizens' experience of accessing police services. Even where reporting mechanisms exist, delays at the police station may discourage victims from pursuing complaints, particularly in cases involving financial loss or repeated follow-up.

Registering and pursuing a complaint rarely ends with a single visit, as highlighted in Table 5. While 31% of victims reported visiting the police station only once or twice, nearly one in four had to return five times or more (23%). Victims in rural areas reported double the incidence of five or more visits to the police station (38%) compared to those residing in urban areas (19%). Repeated visits involve lost work hours, travel expenses, and administrative uncertainty, highlighting the need for more efficient

The gaps in cyber policing

For cybercrime victims, the challenges can continue well beyond the first step of reporting a complaint

Table 1: Index of satisfaction with police's handling of cybercrime

Level of satisfaction	(%)
Very satisfied	17
Somewhat satisfied	20
Somewhat dissatisfied	42
Very dissatisfied	21

Note: The index was created from these questions posed to victims: police helpline number for cyber complaints, online police portal for cybercrime, complaint registration process at cyber police station and investigation of cybercrimes by the police.



Table 2: Satisfaction of the victims of cybercrimes with various police services

	Degree of satisfaction (victims)				
	Very satisfied	Somewhat satisfied	Somewhat dissatisfied	Very dissatisfied	Never used these services*
Police helpline number for cybercrime complaints	18	32	13	14	20
Online police portal for cybercrime	16	31	13	12	24
Complaint registration process at the cyber police station	16	30	14	12	23
Investigation of cybercrime by the police	17	26	13	17	22

**This was a silent option and was only coded if the respondent explicitly said that.*

Note: All figures are in percentages. The rest did not respond. The table includes responses only from the victims.
Question asked: How satisfied were you with the following – very satisfied, somewhat satisfied, somewhat dissatisfied, or very dissatisfied?

Table 3: Satisfaction with police handling cybercrime by gender

Gender	Index of satisfaction with police handling cybercrime			
	Very satisfied	Somewhat satisfied	Somewhat dissatisfied	Very dissatisfied
Male	19	21	42	18
Female	15	17	42	26

Table 4: Wait time (hours) at the police station to get complaint registered

Hours	(%)
1 hour or less	29
2 to 3 hours	34
4 to 5 hours	11
More than 5 hours	4

*Note: The rest did not respond.
All figures are in percentages.
The table includes responses only
from the victims.*

Table 5: Number of visits to the police station

Number of times	(%)
Once or twice	31
Three or four times	24
Five times or more	23

Note: The rest did not respond. All figures are in percentages. The table includes responses only from the victims.

Table 6: Overall ease of registering a police complaint about cybercrime

Ease	(%)
Very easy	26
Somewhat easy	31
Somewhat difficult	25
Very difficult	17

Note: The rest did not respond. All figures in percentages. The table includes responses only from the victims.

case management and better communication during investigations.

Table 6 shows that victims' experiences of registering a complaint are mixed. A modest majority (57%) describe the process as very or somewhat easy, but 42% find it somewhat or very difficult. Across gender, women respondents were more likely to rate the process easier than men (61% and 54%, respectively).

India's cyber policing architecture has expanded rapidly over the past decade, reflecting the growing recognition of digital crime as a major governance challenge. However, the experiences of cybercrime victims suggest that

institutional capacity is still uneven where it matters most: investigation, follow-up and victim support. The findings underline a broader lesson for policing reforms: strengthening public trust requires moving beyond easier reporting mechanisms towards a system that is responsive, transparent and capable of delivering timely justice.

Krishangi Sinha is a researcher at Lokniti-CSDS. Views expressed are personal. This analysis is based on data collected during a comprehensive study on *The Status of Policing in India Report 2026* jointly conducted by Lokniti-CSDS & Common Cause.

‘Southwest monsoon ends with 12% deficit’

The IMD director-general told media on Wednesday that the IMD’s predictions matched conditions in “many regions, except some parts of northwest and adjoining central India”.

The department’s regional and monthly forecasts were far off the mark. June, which got only 65% of normal rainfall, was far drier than the 92% forecast. July rainfall, which was expected to be below 94%, ended up with 1% more, thanks to rains in central India, which got 33% more rain than normal. August came in at 84% of the LPA, in line with the “below 94%” that was forecast. September, at 92.4% finished a little above the forecast of “below 91%”.

The largest deviations from normal rainfall were in east and northeast India (25.6% below normal). Mr. Mohapatra said that there was a “marked trend” of diminishing rainfall in this region “in recent years”. Rainfall in the southern peninsula was 24.3% below normal, and at 542 mm, this was the fourth lowest monsoon rainfall recorded in the region since 1901. Northwest India ended 5.9% below normal and central India stood at 2.6% below normal, according to an IMD statement.

Punjab, Arunachal Pradesh, and the Assam & Meghalaya subdivisions were rain-deficient in every month from June to September. Nationally, 17 of 36 subdivisions (covering 42% of the country’s land area) saw deficient rainfall, 18 were normal, and one had excess rain. Of 741 districts assessed, 282 were deficient and 34 were “large deficient”.

Modi, Trump talk trade, defence, critical technologies over a call

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

In their first telephone call since the United States Congress passed the new Russian sanctions law, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he and President Donald Trump had a “productive conversation” and reviewed bilateral ties. Mr. Modi and Mr. Trump spoke amid growing concerns over the India-U.S. relationship, underlined by a talk by External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar in New York earlier this week where he spelt out a number of “issues”, including over tariffs, FTA negotiations, the U.S.’s treatment of Indian migrants and Pakistan.

The call between the two leaders followed talks between Mr. Jaishankar and U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio as well as Foreign Secretary Vikram



Donald Trump and Narendra Modi. FILE PHOTO

Misri and U.S. Undersecretary of State Allison Hooker on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA).

Sanctions on Russia
During both meetings, Indian officials had raised concerns over the U.S.’s new Lindsey O Graham Sanctions Against Russia and Iran Act (SRIA), which mandates Mr. Trump to levy up to 100% tariffs on goods imported from In-

dia, China and other countries that import Russian oil. Mr. Misri also raised the issues with a U.S. Congressional delegation in Delhi this week.

In a social media post, Mr. Modi said he and Mr. Trump discussed India-U.S. cooperation in “trade, defence, energy, critical technologies and other areas”, but made no direct reference to the SRIA.

‘Close engagement’
“We agreed to maintain close engagement to take our Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership forward. We also exchanged views on regional and international issues, including ongoing efforts to advance global peace and security,” he said.

Mr. Modi is expected to travel to Florida in December to attend the G20 summit hosted by Mr. Trump.

SC rules out total ban on firecrackers for Deepavali

Court sees worth in CSIR-NEERI report on new-generation joined green crackers with lower noise, particulate emissions, and solid waste generation; Bench mulls specific time windows for bursting

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Ruling out a nationwide ban on firecrackers, the Supreme Court on Wednesday accepted suggestions by the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (CSIR-NEERI) for a “limited and conditional relaxation”.

The court backed the premier scientific body’s recommendations for manufacture of next-generation joined green crackers in compliance with applicable noise, emission, and safety requirements ahead of Deepavali festivities.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Justice M.M. Sundresh, Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, for the Centre, said CSIR-NEERI has recommended that green crackers conform to specifications/formulations tested and approved by the competent authority and are made exclusively by duly-licensed manufacturers.



The court says it will take a balanced view, particularly over anxiety of air pollution with the onset of winter. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

CSIR-NEERI has suggested that crackers must be within the prescribed noise limit of 125 dB (A)/145 dB(C) peak and strictly fall within permissible emission brackets, Ms. Bhati said.

The law officer submitted that CSIR-NEERI has prescribed the shell size, shell number and bursting duration/time of green crackers, which showed less noise and emissions than conventional joined crackers. The scientific report underscored that these crackers should be free of banned chemical ingredients.

The CSIR-NEERI report

on the “new-generation joined firecrackers” said a series of the green variety had been developed without the use of barium in their compositions. These crackers were different from the conventional ones in terms of shell/tube size, formulation, bursting duration, and frequency of bursting, with corresponding reductions in noise, particulate emissions and solid waste generation, the report said.

30% reduction

Tests conducted on them show a 30% reduction in emissions compared to conventional joined crack-

ers. The shrinking of the shell size has also reduced solid waste generation from 4% up to 32%, the report said.

“The bursting time duration has increased five times in the next-generation joined green crackers,” the report noted.

The court said it would take a balanced view on the issue of firecrackers, particularly with apprehensions of air pollution with the onset of winter and the festive season.

“Total ban will hurt certain sentiments. We will not agree on a total ban across the country. At the same time, we will not allow a 24-hour bursting anywhere, as it affects the sick, the elderly, and children,” the Bench remarked orally.

The court said it would look into directing specific time windows for bursting crackers.

The court gave more time to the Central Pollution Control Board and the Union government to continue with further barium and joined firecracker tests to test decibel levels.

NCERT textbook revives debatable theory on *Sengol* handed to Nehru at Independence

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The Union government’s claim that a *Sengol*, which is a sceptre anointed by Hindu religious leaders, marked the transfer of power in 1947 when India became Independent, finds a mention in the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)’s newly released Class 9 social science textbook.

The new textbook, *Understanding Society: India and Beyond - Part Two*, says, “The *Sengol*, a cultural marker of rulership and good governance, was placed in India’s newly inaugurated Parliament building in 2023 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The tradition of using the *Sengol* as a mark of righteous governance began more than a thousand years ago during the reign of Chola dynasty,” the textbook reads.

“To mark the occasion of India’s Independence, at the stroke of midnight on 15 August 1947, the first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, received the *Sengol* from the Adheenam saints (an old Shaivite tradition) of Tamil Nadu,” it says.

Ethical responsibilities

Describing the *Sengol*, the website of the Union Culture Ministry says, “Once integral to the coronation rites of Tamil monarchs, the *Sengol* was not merely a ceremonial object but a profound testament to the ethical responsibilities bestowed upon a ruler. This sacred tradition was momentarily revived on the eve of India’s independence in 1947, when a *Sengol* was solemnly presented to Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru. It marked the ‘civilisationally rooted’ transfer of authority from colonial rule to a sovereign Indian state.”

This theory has been



The *Sengol*, a sceptre from Tamil Nadu, that was installed in the new Parliament building in May 2023. FILE PHOTO

contradicted time and again by experts. For instance, historian and biographer of C. Rajagopalachari, Rajmohan Gandhi has earlier said in public domain during the inauguration of the new Parliament building that there is no record of the *Sengol* serving as a formal symbol of the “transfer of power”, in the personal papers, letters or autobiographies of either Nehru or Rajaji.

Historian Aditya Muk-

herjee had also criticised the 2023 ceremony and the installation of the *Sengol*, stating that the event was an effort of political self-glorification rather than celebrating parliamentary democracy.

The textbook says India’s national motto – *Satyameva Jayate* – is linked to Mundaka Upanishad replacing the British-era “Heaven’s Light, Our Guide”. The textbook says the Supreme Court’s post-Independence motto *Yato Dharmastato Jayah*, which translates into “Where there is righteous duty, there is victory”, is linked to the Mahabharata. This is stated in the chapter “Governance and Public Policy” of the new textbook.

The chapter links Mahatma Gandhi’s reference to *Ram Rajya*, which is an ideal governance structure based on probity, transparency, compassion, and welfare, to the Ramayana and the 16th century liter-

ary work *Ramcharitmanas*, calling these two texts “examples of good governance and good collective life”.

‘Sacred responsibility’

The textbook says that from the Vedic period to the Ramayana and Mahabharata, Indian traditions viewed governance as a “sacred responsibility” rather than merely a means of exercising power.

The chapter says that colonial powers imposed their models of governance on societies which had previously followed “local and organic systems”, and that many colonial institutions have continued since Independence.

In another chapter titled “Resistance and Resilience”, the textbook says many kings and princes are believed to have received swords from goddesses such as Kali, Durga and Bhavani to resist invasions since the 7th century.

Centre notifies CAFE norms, tightens PVs’ fuel-efficiency targets

Tighter fuel-consumption targets from 2027-32 will also offer credits for hybrids, flex-fuel vehicles, biofuels and efficiency technologies

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The Centre has notified the third phase of carbon emission norms for passenger vehicles (PVs), effective from April 1, 2027 to March 31, 2032, under which each battery electric vehicle (EV) will count as three vehicles toward a carmaker’s fleet-efficiency calculation, while other cleaner technologies and biofuel-based vehicles will receive specified credits.

Under the new norms, the fuel-consumption benchmark will be tightened from 3.996 litre per 100 km in 2027-28 to 3.3273 litre per 100 km in 2031-32, amounting to an improvement of about 16.7% over the five-year period. The new norms will apply to new passenger vehicles manufactured or



New template: The norms broadly cover passenger cars, including hatchbacks, sedans and special utility vehicles. . GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

imported for sale in India.

The Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE) norms use 1,229 kg as the reference vehicle weight. The earlier concession for small cars weighing up to 909 kg has been removed following a pitched fight that split the auto industry.

The fleet’s average fuel consumption will be calculated using the Modified Indian Driving Cycle (MIDC)

and expressed in petrol-equivalent litre per 100 km. For individual models, fuel consumption will be calculated using their notified tailpipe CO₂ emissions. Diesel, LPG, CNG and electric vehicles will be converted into petrol-equivalent figures using specified conversion factors. For electric vehicles, energy consumption will be measured in kWh per 100 km.

Cabinet approves ₹1.86 lakh crore Green Energy Corridor

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet announced the third phase of the Green Energy Corridor (GEC) that seeks to integrate up to 135 gigawatts of renewable energy into grids across States and Union Territories by fiscal year 2032-33.

The scheme would further strive to address curtailment, that is a situation when grid operators limit the power output from



Power play: About ₹1.36 lakh crore would be spent on developing intra-state transmission systems in phase 3. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

renewable sources to maintain grid stability. *The Hindu* had reported

August 10 that the government was in the final planning stages of instituting

the third phase of the GEC.

Project outlay

The third phase of the scheme accounts for a total project outlay of more than ₹1.86 lakh crore.

This comprises ₹1.36 lakh crore for developing intra-state transmission systems in the third phase. As a first, the latest phase of GEC also provisions a ₹50,000-crore dedicated component for deploying 50 GWh of battery energy storage system (BESS).